Q+A

# DREAM RUN

The critics may be frowning but **Ayushmann Khurrana**'s *Dream Girl 2* is yet another commercial success

**Q. What is the one thing that *Dream Girl*–both parts–changed in you?**
I'd like to believe I put women on a pedestal. But of late, through these roles, I have learnt to respect women more. Pooja, the character I played, was different. In *Dream Girl* (2019), the emphasis was on the voice. *Dream Girl 2* was tougher–the physicality was not the only challenge, trust me. Pooja made me learn a lot about the craft of acting. That thin line between looking the part and being a caricature wasn't easy. It's a slapstick, commercial film, but we ensured it didn't become vulgar.

**Q. Is it a conscious choice to do cinema that is off-centre? What about commercial concerns?**
I do want to create clutter-breaking work. This involves consciously choosing to do work that is unconventional, yet relatable. I'm glad that's happened for me, right from *Vicky Donor* (2012). The idea is to do cinema that starts conversations... I feel if the content is strong, audiences will watch it. If we only chase commercial gains and do what's 'acceptable', we'll limit ourselves.

**Q. Does that also apply to your work as a singer?**
Oh, absolutely! I yearn for stuff that hasn't been heard before. Doing one song in two-three years makes it that much more important. Music is a purer form of expression, and my passion. So any song I do has to stand out, in terms of meaning, music and expression. My song has to be me!

**Q. Your next few films are mostly sequels or remakes...**
You've done your research! *(laughs)* Yes, a few of them are, but I'm looking forward to them regardless. The challenge with a sequel or remake is to take yourself and the film to the next level. I'm also excited about working with new people, talented directors and gifted storytellers like Mudassar Aziz and Dinesh Vijan. I am not telling you more!

with Aarti Kapur Singh



Photograph by HARDIK CHHABRA